



Female Entrepreneurs: gender diversity across the UK’s high-growth ecosystem

We’ve highlighted key trends amongst, and disparities between, all-female, mixed-gender and all-male founding teams; from the funding they’ve received to the key support systems they’ve leveraged.

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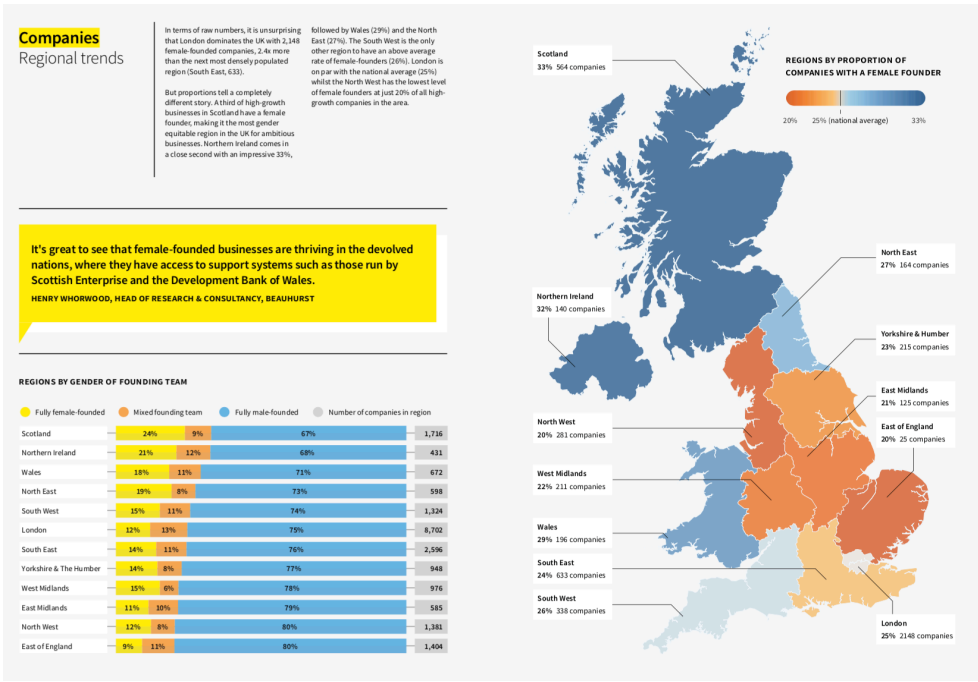
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What's inside?



Companies
25% of the UK's high-growth companies have a female founder, but which regions have a particularly high proportion and which may need more support?

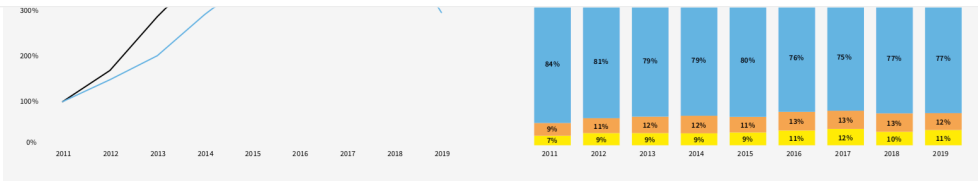
Equity investment
The proportion of equity deals secured by teams with a female founder has increased from 14% in 2011 to a high of 22% in 2017. This figure has plateaued since.

Grant funding
Since 2012 the share of large innovation grants awarded to female founders has quadrupled to 16% – still a very low proportion.

accelerators
Fully-female-founded companies are most likely to have grown through an accelerators, more commonly opting for structure programmes instead of funding transactions.

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Grants
Overview

The distribution of grant funding in the UK is one of the most alarming examples of gender disparity within the ecosystem. There has been no progression in the proportion of large innovation grants (£100k) awarded to all female founding teams, which have consistently received just 4-5% of this grant type since 2012. But figures are steadily improving for mixed-gender founding teams, who have grown their share of large innovation grants from 2% in 2012 to 12% in 2019 so far. Still, this figure is very low. So what are the possible reasons for this?

Firstly, there are fewer female-founded companies in the sectors that are most frequently awarded grants than there are across the high-growth population as a whole. 69% of large innovation grants are deployed to companies in the technology and IP sector, within which only 19% of companies have a female founder.

Drilling down into the most common emerging sectors associated with grant recipients, the UK's ambitious artificial intelligence and Internet of Things companies are made up of just 13%

and 17% of female-founded businesses, respectively. But even taking these sector weightings into account, the proportion of grants going to female-founded companies is still lower than what we might expect.

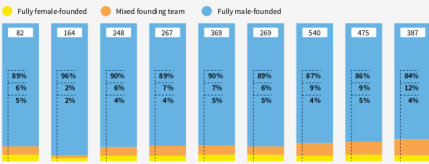
So where else is there a leak? In 2016, Innovate UK found that just 14% of grant applications came from women entrepreneurs. Subsequently, Innovate UK launched the Women in Innovation programme, consisting of a number of initiatives. One element is a partnership

with Getty Images to deliver a series of portraits shattering gender stereotypes, and installing commemorative plaques across the country to recognise female innovators. These are certainly a longer-term play, encouraging younger generations to excel in science and business, building the pool of female founder talent in the long run.

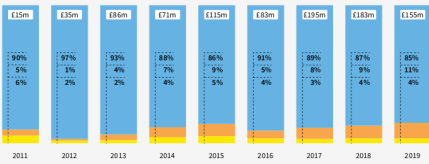
Another aspect of the programme is a woman-only funding competition. This provides specialist support for female founders who are already willing and

able to scale their businesses. 9 winners have each received £50k and a bespoke package of support. Although this isn't classed as a 'large innovation grant', these are still an important part of the ecosystem, helping to build awareness and get more women entrepreneurs involved in programmes.

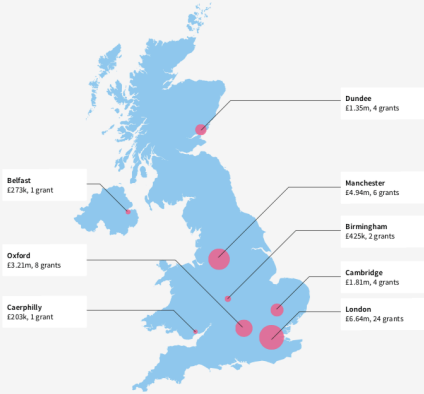
GRANT NUMBERS BY GENDER OF RECIPIENT'S FOUNDING TEAM



TOTAL VALUE OF GRANTS BY GENDER OF RECIPIENT'S FOUNDING TEAM



TOP CITIES BY VALUE OF GRANTS AWARDED TO FEMALE-FOUNDED COMPANIES IN 2018



Accelerators
Overview

Accelerators are the most popular method of growth for female-founded businesses, and the only method to have an over-representation of women entrepreneurs. Despite making up 25% of the high-growth business population,

is a little lower for mixed-gender teams (18%). All male founding teams are the most likely to have progressed to a later stage of evolution following an accelerator attendance.

We currently track two accelerators that provide specialist support for female founders, Hatch's Female Founders and We in Social Tech. Run by Hatch Enterprise, Female Founders is a 4-month programme 'to help female-led

Some accelerators may invest money, but they will also help develop entrepreneurs' skills and grow the business, and I think female founders in particular are drawn to

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HANNAH SKINGLE

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